1 Jews, Arabs and the British 1900–39

POINTS TO CONSIDER

Both Jews and Arabs claimed Palestine, but it was the British who took control of the land after the First World War. This chapter will start by examining the claims of both Arabs and Jews and then it will explain why and how Britain ruled Palestine from 1919 until 1939. These developments are examined under the headings:

- The Jewish claim to Palestine
- The Arab claim to Palestine
- British rule in Palestine 1919–39

Key dates

1915	McMahon–Hussein letters
1916	Sykes–Picot Agreement
	The Arab Revolt
1917	Balfour Declaration
1919	Britain granted mandate over Palestine
1933	Hitler came to power in Germany
1936–9	The Arab Rebellion
1937	Peel Commission recommended partition of Palestine
1939	British government White Paper

1 | The Jewish Claim to Palestine

Key question
What was the Jewish claim to Palestine?

The expulsion of the Jews from Palestine

The Jewish people lived in the land of Palestine (see map on page 9) from about 1500 BC. In the time of Jesus – first century AD – Palestine was ruled by the Romans. In AD 70 and again in AD 135 the Jews rebelled against their Roman rulers. Roman soldiers crushed both revolts, destroyed the Jewish temple, the city of Jerusalem and expelled most of the Jews. Many thousands fled to neighbouring countries and, over the next 200 years, they settled in almost every part of the Roman Empire, particularly in southern Europe. The Jews thus became a scattered people and only a few thousand remained in Palestine. Many of those who lived in the **diaspora** became merchants and farmers, bankers and craftsmen. Some became wealthy and even gained important positions in the governments of the new lands in which they

Key term
Diaspora
The dispersal of Jews in many different parts of the world.